SRIVIDYA ANGARA SINHA PRESENTS

MANOMANTHANA

Exploring Struggle, Silence, and Stillness

SOLO THEMATIC KUCHIPUDI DANCE PRODUCTION BASED ON THE KRITIS OF SRI THYAGARAJA SWAMI

The Churning *Manthana · Mano*

Manthana is a Sanskrit term used to depict the act of churning. When prefixed with Mano, it becomes the stirring of and within the mind; an intense, and concentrated movement of thought that upon reaching a crescendo yields the object of desire. Through this inner debate, the protagonist delves into her deepest emotions, churning them with a manic passion that will ultimately lead to ONE answer that will quell all questions.

A Spiritual Seeker in a Chaotic Today

A spiritual seeker in a chaotic today, our protagonist, the dancer is in turmoil. There is a want to exceed the mundane, the everyday. But the determined pull of digression and diversion exist – both inside and outside. As a dancer, there is a need to be in the outer world, to interact with it, so as to get to a literal stage where it is possible to fully experience a sense of the sublime. However, this fullness of emotion only lasts a moment. And it is in recreating that moment that one is willing to put oneself through all the chaos, all over again.

THE QUESTIONS TUMBLE IN QUICKLY

A finite body, a finite time frame, and a desire to be one with the Infinite.
Where does it begin? Where does it end? And how intense is intense enough?

Battling a downward spiral of doubt and despondency, our protagonist churns her emotions to a state of frenzied intensity. Is the emotion stirred intense enough to break the barriers she has erected in her mind? What then, happens next?

The Form

Kuchipudi · Thyagaraja · Vachana

All this and MUCH MORE gets explored through this hour-long production that makes use of traditional Carnatic music from South India, in tandem with the dramatic idiom of KUCHIPUDI – one of the most celebrated classical dance styles of India. The music and lyric used is the work of saint-poet THYAGARAJA - foremost amongst the classical Carnatic vaaggeyakaaras. The lyrical pieces which are otherwise disparate when viewed individually, come together through the time-honoured tradition of vachana, or soliloquy that is distinctive to Kuchipudi.

The Ensemble

The musicians who have come together for this mammoth task are

Vidushi Smt. Ranjani Sivakumar Siddareddy	VOCALS
Vidwan Sri G Gurumurthy	MRIDANGAM
Vidwan Sri D V Prasanna Kumar	NATTUVANGAM
Vidwan Sri Jayaram Kikkeri	FLUTE
Vidwan Sri Pradesh Achar	VIOLIN
Vidwan Sri Somashekhar Jois	KONNAKKOL
Vidwan Sri Akash Parva	KEYBOARD AND EFFECTS

Sound design is by Aravind Studio, and Omkaar Sound Studios.

WITH GRATITUDE

A debt of gratitude to renowned Kuchipudi Guru Sri JaiKishore Mosalikanti for his invaluable presence and guidance in helping shape this production into what it is today.

THE INTENT

Conceptualized, scripted and choreographed by Bengaluru-based Kuchipudi dancer Srividya Angara Sinha, this novel production aims to move beyond the ephemeral and touch the eternal using the timeless lyric of Thyagaraja and the kinetic theatre of Kuchipudi.

Performed at

Solo thematic production

— Ananya Nruthya Sangama, Bengaluru

— Bangalore International Centre, Bengaluru

— Hyderabad Thyagaraja Aradhana Music Festival, Hyderabad

— Sundarayya Kala Bhavan, Hyderabad

— Jagriti Theatre, Bengaluru — two back-to-back shows

— Pattabhi Rama Temple, Thiruvayyaru

— Navaneetha Krishna Temple, Thanjavur

— Premiered before the Rama vigrahas worshipped by saint-poet Sri Thyagaraja, Thanjavur

"...articulation of bhavas through abhinayam was a real treat to the audience..."
TELANGANA TODAY

"...steeped in grace and emotion....explored the profound inner conflicts of human mind and heart, beautifully illustrated by Thyagaraja's kritis."
THE NEW INDIAN EXPRESS

"...Her ability to bring realism to her performance was so powerful that it brought tears to spectators' eyes..."
METRO INDIA

"...Evocative..."

EENADU

"...captivating..."

SAAKSHI

"...An hour-long journey that traces the vicissitudes, ebb and flow, crests and troughs of the seeker straining to meet and consequently merge with Lord Rama... had moments that touched hearts..."

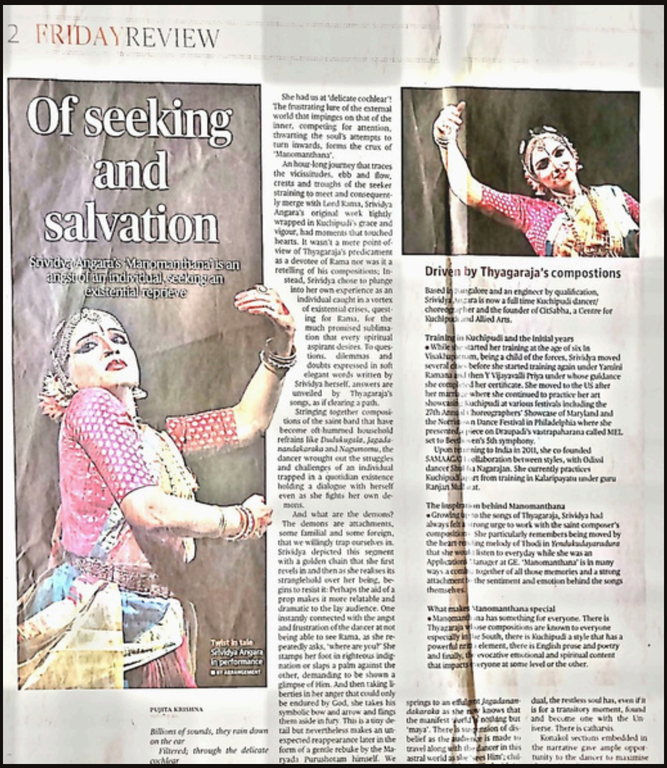
THE HINDU, BY PUJITA KRISHNA

"...emotion-filled singing, supportive instruments, appropriate sound effects, modulation in Vachanas, above all Srividya's expressive abhinaya predominant with bhakti and powerful footwork together contributed to the success of the production..."

THE HINDU, BY DR. RAAMA KAUSALYA

ON THE COVER
Featured on the cover of Ananya Kalasinchana, a prestigious 25-year-old global arts magazine based in Bengaluru.

THE CLIPPINGS



Of seeking and salvation

Srividya Angara's 'Manomanthana' is an angst of an individual, seeking an existential reprieve

Twist in tale
Srividya Angara in performance
■ BY ARRANGEMENT

PUJITA KRISHNA

Billions of sounds, they rain down on the ear
Filtered; through the delicate cochlear

She had us at 'delicate cochlear'! The frustrating lure of the external world that impinges on that of the inner, competing for attention, thwarting the soul's attempts to turn inwards, forms the crux of 'Manomanthana'.

An hour-long journey that traces the vicissitudes, ebb and flow, crests and troughs of the seeker straining to meet and consequently merge with Lord Rama, Srividya Angara's original work tightly wrapped in Kuchipudi's grace and vigour, had moments that touched hearts. It wasn't a mere point-of-view of Thyagaraja's predicament as a devotee of Rama nor was it a retelling of his compositions; Instead, Srividya chose to plunge into her own experience as an individual caught in a vortex of existential crises, questing for Rama, for the much promised sublimation that every spiritual aspirant desires. To questions, dilemmas and doubts expressed in soft elegant words written by Srividya herself, answers are unveiled by Thyagaraja's songs, as if clearing a path.

Stringing together compositions of the saint bard that have become oft-hummed household refrains like *Dudukugala*, *Jagadanandakaraka* and *Nagumomu*, the dancer wrought out the struggles and challenges of an individual trapped in a quotidian existence holding a dialogue with herself even as she fights her own demons.

And what are the demons? The demons are attachments, some familial and some foreign, that we willingly trap ourselves in. Srividya depicted this segment with a golden chain that she first revels in and then as she realises its stranglehold over her being, begins to resist it: Perhaps the aid of a prop makes it more relatable and dramatic to the lay audience. One instantly connected with the angst and frustration of the dancer at not being able to see Rama, as she repeatedly asks, 'where are you?' She stamps her foot in righteous indignation or slaps a palm against the other, demanding to be shown a glimpse of Him. And then taking liberties in her anger that could only be endured by God, she takes his symbolic bow and arrow and flings them aside in fury. This is a tiny detail but nevertheless makes an unexpected reappearance later in the form of a gentle rebuke by the Maryada Purushotam himself. We

springs to an effulgent *Jagadanandakaraka* as the now knows that the manifest world is nothing but 'maya'. There is suspension of disbelief as the audience is made to travel along with the dancer in this astral world as she 'sees Him'; chil-

dual, the restless soul has, even if it is for a transitory moment, found and become one with the Universe. There is catharsis.

Kontakol sections embedded in the narrative gave ample opportunity to the dancer to maximise

Driven by Thyagaraja's compostions

Based in Bangalore and an engineer by qualification, Srividya Angara is now a full time Kuchipudi dancer/choreographer and the founder of CitSabha, a Centre for Kuchipudi and Allied Arts.

Training in Kuchipudi and the initial years

- While she started her training at the age of six in Visakhapatnam, being a child of the forces, Srividya moved several cities before she started training again under Yamini Ramana and then Y Vijayavalli Priya under whose guidance she completed her certificate. She moved to the US after her marriage where she continued to practice her art showcasing Kuchipudi at various festivals including the 27th Annual Choreographers' Showcase of Maryland and the Norristown Dance Festival in Philadelphia where she presented a piece on Draupadi's vastrapaharana called MEL set to Beethoven's 5th symphony.

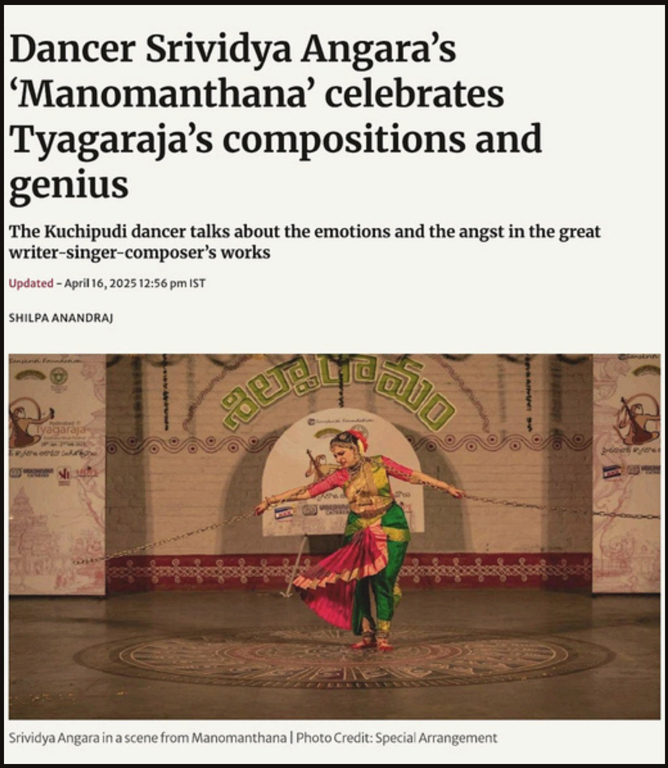
Upon returning to India in 2011, she co founded SAMAAGAM, a collaboration between styles, with Odissi dancer [illegible] Nagarajan. She currently practices Kuchipudi apart from training in Kalaripayatu under guru Ranjan Mullarat.

The inspiration behind Manomanthana

- Growing up to the songs of Thyagaraja, Srividya had always felt a strong urge to work with the saint composer's compositions. She particularly remembers being moved by the heart rending melody of Thodi in *Yendukudayaradura* that she would listen to everyday while she was an Applications Manager at GE. "Manomanthana" is in many ways a coming together of all those memories and a strong attachment to the sentiment and emotion behind the songs themselves.

What makes Manomanthana special

- Manomanthana has something for everyone. There is Thyagaraja whose compositions are known to everyone especially in the South, there is Kuchipudi a style that has a powerful natya element, there is English prose and poetry and finally, the evocative emotional and spiritual content that impacts everyone at some level or the other.



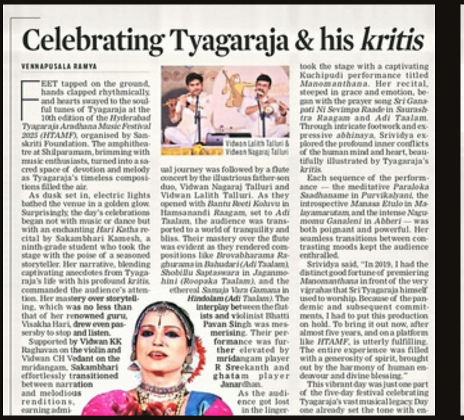
Dancer Srividya Angara's 'Manomanthana' celebrates Tyagaraja's compositions and genius

The Kuchipudi dancer talks about the emotions and the angst in the great writer-singer-composer's works

Updated - April 16, 2025 12:56 pm IST

SHILPA ANANDRAJ

Srividya Angara in a scene from Manomanthana | Photo Credit: Special Arrangement



Celebrating Tyagaraja & his *kritis*

VENNAPUSALA RAMYA

Vidwan Lalith Talluri & Vidwan Nagaraj Talluri

FEET tapped on the ground, hands clapped rhythmically, and hearts swayed to the soulful tunes of Tyagaraja at the 10th edition of the *Hyderabad Tyagaraja Aradhana Music Festival 2025 (HTAMF)*, organised by Sanskriti Foundation. The amphitheatre at Shilparamam, brimming with music enthusiasts, turned into a sacred space of devotion and melody as Tyagaraja's timeless compositions filled the air.

As dusk set in, electric lights bathed the venue in a golden glow. Surprisingly, the day's celebrations began not with music or dance but with an enchanting *Hari Katha* recital by Sakambhari Kamesh, a ninth-grade student who took the stage with the poise of a seasoned storyteller. Her narrative, blending captivating anecdotes from Tyagaraja's life with his profound *kritis*, commanded the audience's attention. Her mastery over storytelling, which was no less than that of her renowned guru, Visakha Hari, drew even passersby to stop and listen.

Supported by Vidwan KK Raghavan on the violin and Vidwan CH Vedant on the mridangam, Sakambhari effortlessly transitioned between narration and melodious renditions, earning admi-

ual journey was followed by a flute concert by the illustrious father-son duo, Vidwan Nagaraj Talluri and Vidwan Lalith Talluri. As they opened with *Bantu Reeti Koluvu* in Hamsanandi *Raagam*, set to *Adi Taalam*, the audience was transported to a world of tranquility and bliss. Their mastery over the flute was evident as they rendered compositions like *Brovabharama Raghurama* in *Bahudari (Adi Taalam)*, *Shobillu Saptaswara* in *Jaganmohini (Roopaka Taalam)*, and the ethereal *Samaja Vara Gamana* in *Hindolam (Adi Taalam)*. The interplay between the flutists and violinist Bhatti Pavan Singh was mesmerising. Their performance was further elevated by mridangam player R Sreekanth and ghatam player Janardhan.

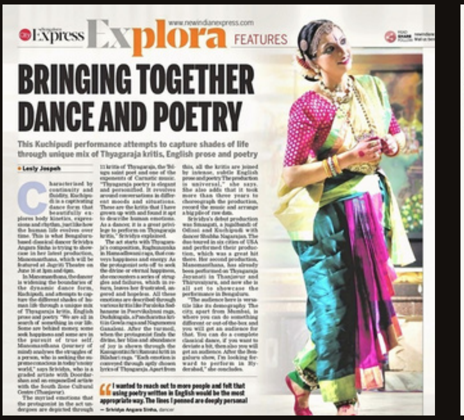
As the audience got lost in the linger-

took the stage with a captivating Kuchipudi performance titled *Manomanthana*. Her recital, steeped in grace and emotion, began with the prayer song *Sri Ganapati Ni Sevimpa Raade* in *Saurashtra Raagam* and *Adi Taalam*. Through intricate footwork and expressive *abhinaya*, Srividya explored the profound inner conflicts of the human mind and heart, beautifully illustrated by Tyagaraja's *kritis*.

Each sequence of the performance — the meditative *Paraloka Saadhaname* in *Purvikalyani*, the introspective *Manasa Etulo* in *Malayamarutam*, and the intense *Nagumomu Ganaleni* in *Abheri* — was both poignant and powerful. Her seamless transitions between contrasting moods kept the audience enthralled.

Srividya said, "In 2019, I had the distinct good fortune of premiering *Manomanthana* in front of the very vigrahas that Sri Tyagaraja himself used to worship. Because of the pandemic and subsequent commitments, I had to put this production on hold. To bring it out now, after almost five years, and on a platform like *HTAMF*, is utterly fulfilling. The entire experience was filled with a generosity of spirit, brought out by the harmony of human endeavour and divine blessing."

This vibrant day was just one part of the five-day festival celebrating Tyagaraja's vast musical legacy. Day one already set the tone with en-



Express Explora FEATURES www.newindianexpress.com

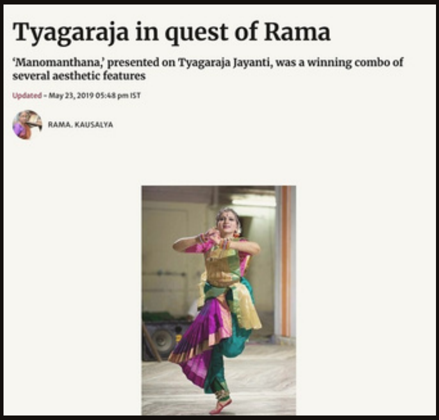
BRINGING TOGETHER DANCE AND POETRY

This Kuchipudi performance attempts to capture shades of life through unique mix of Thyagaraja kritis, English prose and poetry

Lesly Jospeh

I wanted to reach out to more people and felt that using poetry written in English would be the most appropriate way. The lines I penned are deeply personal

— Srividya Angara Sinha, dancer

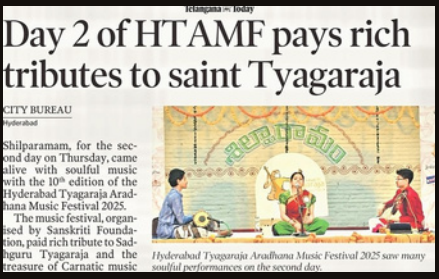


Tyagaraja in quest of Rama

'Manomanthana,' presented on Tyagaraja Jayanti, was a winning combo of several aesthetic features

Updated - May 23, 2019 05:48 pm IST

RAMA. KAUSALYA



Telangana Today

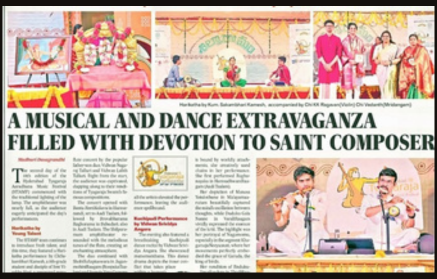
Day 2 of HTAMF pays rich tributes to saint Tyagaraja

CITY BUREAU
Hyderabad

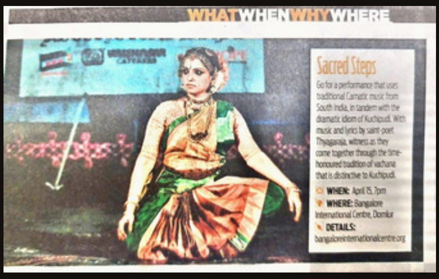
Shilparamam, for the second day on Thursday, came alive with soulful music with the 10th edition of the Hyderabad Tyagaraja Aradhana Music Festival 2025.

The music festival, organised by Sanskriti Foundation, paid rich tribute to Sadhguru Tyagaraja and the treasure of Carnatic music

Hyderabad Tyagaraja Aradhana Music Festival 2025 saw many soulful performances on the second day.



A MUSICAL AND DANCE EXTRAVAGANZA FILLED WITH DEVOTION TO SAINT COMPOSER



WHATWHENWHYWHERE

Sacred Steps

Go for a performance that uses traditional Carnatic music from South India, in tandem with the dramatic idiom of Kuchipudi. With music and lyrics by saint-poet Thyagaraja, witness as they come together through the time-honoured tradition of vachana that is distinctive to Kuchipudi.

- **WHEN:** April 15, 7pm
- **WHERE:** Bangalore International Centre, Domlur
- **DETAILS:** bangaloreinternationalcentre.org

Verses of wisdom

A BITTER SWEET symphony

This Kuchipudi performance combines Tyagaraja's poetry with dance and a monologue

అలరించిన సాంస్కృతిక కార్యక్రమాలు

అలరించిన కళాప్రదర్శనలు

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